Official Rules & Regulations

Imagine Cup

2025 Season

Version 1
October 2024
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OVERVIEW
The Imagine Cup is Microsoft's premier global technology startup competition that enables student founders using Artificial Intelligence (AI) and the Microsoft Cloud to turn innovative ideas into market-ready startups. To compete, products must utilize at least one Microsoft AI service. Submissions should include a pitch deck, recorded pitch, and demo video, all addressing the judging criteria outlined in these rules.

SPONSOR
These Official Rules ("Rules") govern the operation of the Microsoft Imagine Cup competition ("Competition"). Microsoft Corporation, One Microsoft Way, Redmond, WA, 98052, USA, is the Competition sponsor ("Sponsor").

DEFINITIONS
In these Rules, "Microsoft", "we," "our," and "us" refer to Sponsor and "you" and "yourself" refers to a Competition entrant, or the parent/legal guardian of any Competition entrant who has not reached the age of majority to contractually obligate themselves in their legal place of residence. By entering, you (your parent/legal guardian if you are not the age of majority in your place of legal residence) agree to be bound by these Rules.

COMPETITION SCHEDULE
This Competition starts at 00:00 Coordinated Universal Time ("UTC") on October 1, 2024 and ends in May 2025 and will consist of multiple rounds as follows. Final dates for the Semifinals and World Championship rounds will be communicated to eligible entrants via email and on your account page on the Imagine Cup website.

ROUND	START DATE (all times 00:00 UTC)	END DATE (all times 23:59 UTC)
Optional Idea Submission Round ("Idea")	October 1, 2024	October 31, 2024
Minimum Viable Product Submission Round ("MVP")	November 1, 2024	January 22, 2025
Semifinals Round ("Semifinals")	February 24, 2025	March 2025
World Championship Round ("World Championship")	March 2025	May 2025

You must submit an entry to the MVP Round to be eligible to advance in the Competition.

ELIGIBILITY
You are eligible to compete if you meet the following requirements below at time of entry, which is defined as the most recent date you have submitted an entry into a specific round.

- **You are** at least 18 years of age as of October 1, 2024; **and**
    - If you are 18 years of age or older but have not reached the age of majority in your legal place of residence, then you must have consent of a parent/legal guardian.

- All team members must be enrolled students at an accredited educational institution that grants high-school or college/university (or equivalent) degrees (including home schools) at any time between October 1, 2024 and May 31, 2025; **and**
- **You are NOT** a resident of Cuba, Iran, North Korea, Sudan, Syria, Russia, and the Region of Crimea; **and**
    - U.S. export regulations prohibit the export of goods and services to Cuba, Iran, North Korea, Sudan, Syria, Russia, and the Region of Crimea. Therefore, residents of these countries/regions are not eligible to participate.
- **You/your business has not** received any dilutive funding; **and**
- **You/your business has not** received external, non-dilutive funding of more than $100,000 USD; **and**
- **You are not** an employee or intern of Microsoft Corporation, or an employee of a Microsoft subsidiary, at any time between October 1, 2024 and May 31, 2025; **and**
- **You are not** involved in any part of the execution or administration of this Competition; **and**
- **You are not** an immediate family member of (parent, sibling, spouse/domestic partner, child) or household member of a Microsoft employee, an employee of a Microsoft subsidiary, or a person involved in any part of the administration and execution of this Competition between October 1, 2024 and May 31, 2025.

If you have previously competed in an Imagine Cup event as a Semifinalist or Regional Finalist, you are eligible to compete only with an entry that is substantially new, unique, and different from anything you've brought to the Imagine Cup before.

Microsoft Learn Student Ambassadors who meet the eligibility criteria set forth above may enter the Competition but cannot use any resources which are not broadly available to all other students in connection with the creation or execution of an entry. This includes using Microsoft property, internal resources, Student Ambassador benefits, and/or the work of Microsoft employees. If you have any questions, please reach out to your Community Program Manager.

This Competition is void outside the geographic area described above and wherever else prohibited by law.

HOW TO ENTER

- Register on the Imagine Cup website and create your team. Additional criteria on teams are listed in the Teams and Mentors section provided later in the rules.
- Follow the submission requirements listed below.
- To submit an entry, visit the Imagine Cup website and follow the instructions to submit your entry.

SUBMISSION REQUIREMENTS

The following criteria apply to all Imagine Cup submissions:

- Your product must be built with and require one (1) or more Microsoft AI service(s) to operate. Microsoft AI service(s) include Azure AI Services, Azure Machine Learning, and Azure AI Studio (now renamed to Azure AI Foundry Portal).

- All submission materials, including your pitch deck materials, recorded videos of your pitch and demo, and live presentations during judging rounds, must be in the English language. While your product may support multiple languages, English must be one of the represented languages.
- All submissions will be evaluated by judges using the relevant competition round judging criteria provided later in these rules.

COMPETITION DETAILS
Below is a description of each competition round and the associated submission requirements. To be eligible, an entry must meet the following requirements for the applicable round.

You may only submit one (1) entry per competition round. We will disqualify any incomplete or illegible entries that we receive or entries that we determine do not meet the above criteria in our sole and absolute discretion. We are not responsible for entries that we do not receive for any reason or for entries that we receive but are not decipherable for any reason. Any attempt by you to obtain more than the stated number of entries by using multiple/different accounts, email addresses, identities, registrations, logins, or any other methods will void your entries and you may be disqualified. Use of any automated system to participate is prohibited.

Optional Round: Idea Submission
Start your journey by structuring your idea using the Lean Canvas framework. This round is optional and not required for submission to the MVP round, but highly recommended to ensure you are building a solution that is technologically innovative, inclusive, and viable. You are required to submit the following:

- **Lean Canvas:** a one-page business model that helps you quickly and effectively communicate your idea and strategy.
    - Upload a PDF of your Lean Canvas. You are welcome to use any platform that you prefer as long as there is a completed Lean Canvas included. Platforms may include Microsoft Word, Microsoft PowerPoint, Microsoft Excel, or Figma. Export or save your file in the application as a PDF. Please do **not** screenshot an image of your Lean Canvas; please export and upload it as a PDF.

Winning the Idea Round: Teams in the Idea Submission round will be evaluated by judges using the Idea judging criteria provided later in these rules. Top submissions will win a mentorship session with an industry expert, where you will have the opportunity to gather feedback on your idea and proposed business model.

Required Round: Minimum Viable Product (MVP) Submission
Develop your minimum viable product (MVP), a functional version of your idea, to advance your solution towards market readiness. Ensure this version is ready for a demo to judges and includes sufficient features and functionality to satisfy early adopters.

You are required to submit the following materials to explain to us what you have built. These materials must collectively address each of the MVP round judging criteria provided later in

these rules. Please note that you must submit all the following materials to this round to compete even if you submitted a Lean Canvas to the Idea Submission round.

Pitch Deck: a slide presentation that you will use to present your startup. We recommend referencing the following resources when building your pitch deck:

- How to pitch your company – module on Microsoft Learn

Your deck must meet the following criteria:

- Your deck must be no more than 15 slides, including an appendix. The file must be in PPT, PPTX, or PDF format. You must include your solution architecture and a comprehensive list of the Microsoft technologies used.
- The solution that you pitch must be fully functional and demonstrable to judges within your demo video (more information below).
- The file must be no larger than 100MB. You may compress your document into a ZIP file for submission.

Recorded Videos, including a 3-minute pitch video and a 2-minute demo video. Both videos must meet all criteria:

- You must provide publicly accessible URLs where the video files can be viewed by judges. We suggest sharing the video via Microsoft OneDrive or other public video hosting platforms.
- You may **not** edit the video in any way except to trim the beginning and/or ending so the video only includes the pitch or demo itself.
- Each video file must be no larger than 100MB. You may compress each file into a ZIP file for submission.
- While only registered team members may participate in the recorded videos, it is not a requirement that all team members be present in the videos.

Pitch Video: a 3-minute maximum video that records your team pitching your startup as if you were pitching live to judges/investors.

- Your video must simulate the experience of a judge viewing your pitch.
- Place your video camera where a judge might sit and then record your pitch to the camera.

Demo Video: a 2-minute maximum narrated video that records your team showing how someone uses your product. This video should mimic a live demo.

- Follow the steps on How to Build a Demo Video from Microsoft for Startups.

Interactive Prototypes (optional): you are welcome but not required to share interactive, high-fidelity prototypes using a prototyping tool (e.g., Figma, Axure) to show your product's functionality and the experience the user will have. These prototypes should mimic the functionality and interaction of the product you are demoing and will share during the technical review should you progress to the semifinals.

- Generate a direct link to your prototypes that is publicly available for judges to review. Do not password protect the prototypes and disable any commenting features if possible.
    - Figma instructions for how to create direct link to prototypes
    - Axure instructions for how to create direct link to prototypes

MVP Round Advancement: Teams in the MVP round will be evaluated by judges using the MVP judging criteria provided later in these rules. The MVP round will result in a minimum of ten (10) teams that will advance to the Semifinal round. This will be communicated no later than February 24, 2025.

Semifinals Round
Gain access to additional benefits to accelerate your growth, including mentorship, global recognition, and expert guidance. In this round, you will participate in a deep dive technical review with Microsoft experts, work on your pitch and strategy with mentors and experts, and pitch live to a virtual panel of judges.

A minimum of eighteen (18) teams will be selected to compete in the Semifinals. This will include a minimum of ten (10) teams, which were selected from the MVP round evaluation process, and a minimum of eight (8) teams from identified university entrepreneurship programs, which will be selected based on an evaluation process with the same judging criteria as the MVP round.

Teams are required to participate in the following activities and submit the following materials, which must collectively address each of the Semifinals judging criteria provided later in these rules.

Technical Review
At the start of the Semifinals round, all semifinalists will undergo a one-time technical review conducted by Microsoft experts. This review aims to ensure that the submitted solutions are authentic and fully functional. You will be asked to walk through and explain your complete solution and architecture so that experts can verify its capabilities and ensure that it meets submission criteria.

Live Pitch and Demo: a 5-minute maximum presentation that will be given live to a panel of judges. The 5-minute allotment will include your core pitch about your startup as well as your working demo. This will be a refined version of the pitch and demo that you submitted to the MVP round.

- Your demo may be live or pre-recorded with live narration.
- You are responsible for your product to be fully installed on suitable hardware for your demo.
- You are responsible for procuring a translator if needed for your live presentation. Microsoft cannot serve as translators for your team.

Semifinals Advancement: Teams in the Semifinals round will be evaluated by judges using the Semifinals judging criteria provided later in these rules. The Semifinals will result in three (3) teams who will advance to the World Championship. No other team rankings will be released. This will be communicated no later than April 4, 2025.

World Championship

The World Championship is the culmination of the competition, where teams continue to hone their pitch with additional mentoring. This round may take place virtually or in person, with the top three teams presenting live to a panel of judges who are experts in their respective field. Competitors must have the same materials prepared as required in the Semifinals round, which is outlined above. At least one (1) member of the team must be present for the World Championship virtually or in person if applicable to compete for the prize.

Winning the World Championship: Teams in the World Championship round will be evaluated by judges using the judging criteria provided later in these rules. Judges will select one (1) first place team and two (2) runners-up teams. No other team rankings will be released.

WINNER SELECTION AND NOTIFICATION

Submissions are reassessed at each stage based on the most recent version submitted or presented.

Judging Criteria – Idea Judging Round:

Criteria	Description	Weighting
Problem Identification and Solution Innovation	• How well does the team identify and articulate the problem that the solution aims to address? • How innovative and effective is the proposed solution in solving the identified problem? • Do they demonstrate a clear understanding of the problem space and a creative approach to addressing it?	**35%**
Value Proposition and Customer Insight	• How clearly does the team define the unique value proposition that makes the solution valuable to customers? • How well do they understand the target customer segments? • Do they show a deep understanding of customer needs and how the solution addresses those needs?	**30%**
Market Strategy	• How effectively does the team outline the channels to reach customers? • How viable are the proposed revenue streams? • How realistic and achievable are the team's plans for acquiring and retaining customers? Have they provided evidence or reasoning to show that their strategies will successfully attract and keep customers? • How well does the team's revenue model support and align with their overall business goals and strategy?	**20%**

Financial Planning and Success Metrics	• How clearly does the team outline the cost structure associated with developing and delivering the solution? • How relevant and effective are the key metrics chosen to measure success? • Do they provide a well-defined cost structure and appropriate metrics to track progress and success?	**15%**

Judging Criteria – MVP, Semifinals and World Championship Rounds:

Criteria	Description	Weighting
AI Technology Implementation	• **Effectiveness of AI:** How well does the team use Microsoft AI services to create an innovative solution? Consider the appropriateness, impact, performance, and innovation of the technologies used. How integral are the AI technologies chosen to the functionality and value proposition of the startup's offerings? • **Innovation and Complexity:** Is the solution innovative and technically complex? Does it solve a real-world problem uniquely? • **Ethical Considerations:** Has the team addressed ethical considerations and implemented responsible AI practices to ensure fairness and mitigate harm?	**40%**
Inclusive Design	• **Accessibility and Usability:** How well does the solution incorporate inclusive design principles to ensure accessibility and usability for diverse users? Consider accommodations for different abilities, ease of use, multilingual support, and customizable settings.	**15%**
Viability	• **Problem Identification:** How well has the team identified a problem and addressed a clear need or opportunity? Is there a clear target audience and defined customer segments? What is the potential market size and demand for the solution? • **Innovation and Differentiation:** Does the solution introduce a new product/service or significantly improve existing ones? How does it stand out from competitors? • **Business Model:** Is the business model feasible and scalable? Have key metrics and customer reach channels been identified? • **Team Skills and Resources:** Does the team have the necessary skills and experience? Have they outlined required resources? • **User Testing and Validation:** Has the team conducted user testing and gathered feedback to refine their solution and validate their assumptions?	**45%**

For the World Championship, each entry will receive a score based on some or all of the criteria mentioned above. There may also include a public voting element. Exact criteria, including the voting process and any limitations, will be published before the World Championship. If public voting is used to help determine scores, it is strictly prohibited to obtain votes through fraudulent or inappropriate means, such as offering prizes or other incentives in exchange for votes, using automated programs, or creating fraudulent IDs. Microsoft reserves the right to void any suspicious votes.

In the event of a tie between any eligible entries, an additional judge will break the tie based on the judging criteria mentioned above. The judges' decisions are final and binding. If we do not receive enough entries meeting the entry requirements, we may, at our discretion, select fewer semifinalists or winners than the number of Contest Prizes described below.

PRIZES

The World Champion will be awarded $100,000 USD and a mentorship call with Microsoft Chairman and CEO Satya Nadella. Each runner-up team will receive $25,000 USD. The prize money will be divided equally among each officially registered member of the team or the incorporated business, paid out via electronic transfer to the registered member's and/or business bank.

All prizes are stated in U.S. dollars, but we, or our local subsidiary or designated agent (on our behalf), may award a cash prize in the official currency of the winner's country of residence based on the exchange rate on the date of payment.

If you are confirmed as a winner:

- You may not exchange non-cash prizes for cash or any other merchandise or services. However, if for any reason an advertised prize is unavailable, we reserve the right to substitute a prize of equal or greater value; **and**
- You may not designate someone else as the winner. If you are unable or unwilling to accept your prize, we may award it to the next highest scoring team/entrant; **and**
- Taxes on the prize, if any, are the sole responsibility of the winner, who is advised to seek independent tax counsel regarding the implications of accepting a prize; **and**
- By accepting a prize, you agree that Microsoft may use your entry, name, image and hometown online and in print, or in any other media, in connection with this Contest without payment or compensation to you, except where prohibited by law; **and**
- If you are otherwise eligible, but have not reached the age of majority in your legal place of residence, then we may award the prize to your parent/legal guardian on your behalf; **and**
- Unless otherwise noted, all prizes are subject to their manufacturer's warranty and/or terms and conditions; **and**
- Mentors of winning teams are not awarded any cash prizes in association with their participation in Imagine Cup.

Notifications:

- Teams advancing to Semifinals and World Championship rounds will be posted as a blog post within seven (7) days following judging. Individual team members advancing will be notified via the contact information provided during entry. If we require you to accept an invitation to compete further or claim a prize, and the notification is returned as undeliverable or you are unreachable, we may disqualify your team and invite the next highest scoring team/entrant.
- The Imagine Cup World Champion will be announced no later than the end of May 2025 as a blog post.
- In case of a dispute regarding the identity of an entrant, we will consider the entrant to be the authorized account holder of the email address provided during entry. The "authorized account holder" is the natural person assigned to an email address by an internet or online service provider, or other organization responsible for assigning email addresses.
- If you are selected as a semifinalist, you will need to sign an Affidavit of Eligibility, Liability and Publicity Release. Any entrant receiving a cash prize will be required to submit a W-9 tax form (for U.S. residents) or W-8BEN tax form (for non-U.S. residents) within the deadline stated in the winner notification.
- If you have not reached the age of majority in your legal place of residence, your parent or legal guardian may need to sign all required forms on your behalf.
- If you do not complete and return the required forms within the specified time period, we may disqualify you and invite the next highest scoring team/entrant.
- If the World Championship takes place in person, you will be responsible for obtaining a valid passport and any necessary visas, along with any associated expenses incurred to procure them. Microsoft will provide a formal invitation letter to assist with the visa process. If in-person travel applies, any expenses not explicitly listed by Microsoft are the sole responsibility of the entrant. If you live within 250 miles of the travel destination, we reserve the right to substitute alternate transportation for air travel. Event dates and locations are subject to change at our sole discretion, so you must have flexible travel capabilities. Travel is subject to availability and must be completed on dates specified by Sponsor or advancement will be forfeited and awarded to the next highest scoring team/entrant. No cancellation or transfer of reservation is allowed after they have been made.

TEAMS AND MENTORS

Up to four (4) eligible students may submit a single entry as a team. Team members may come from different academic institutions and different countries.

- Each competitor may belong to only one team within the competition.
- You may receive assistance with your solution from additional students in specific disciplines beyond the four registered members of your official team and/or from a mentor (typically from academic institutions, not-for profit organizations, or private companies). Additional students and mentors are not considered team members for purposes of these rules. They will not be eligible for any prizes, included in any aspect of the competition rounds or the World Championship award ceremony, or recognized in official communications such as press releases. Only the up to four team members you

officially register with us are eligible for prizes, award ceremony inclusion, and official communications.

- To compete, each team member should create an account at ImagineCup.com and register for the competition. Once registered, any team member can create a new team and invite the remaining team members to join. The remaining team members must accept the invitations before the MVP submission deadline to be recognized as qualified team members.
- If at any time during the Competition you become ineligible after you've submitted an entry, please proactively remove yourself from your team via your ImagineCup.com profile and cease participating. If it is found you've continued to contribute to your team's entry after becoming ineligible, your team may be disqualified.
- If your team is invited to participate in the Semifinals and/or the World Championship, at least one member of your team must attend either virtually or in person, depending on format. If your team is unable to attend virtually and/or in person for any reason, we may disqualify your entire team and invite the next highest-scoring team to participate.
- Each team is solely responsible for its own cooperation and teamwork. In no event will Sponsor officiate any dispute regarding the conduct or cooperation of any team or its members.

The intent and spirit of the Competition is to evaluate and showcase the skills and creativity of the student entrants. Anyone acting as a team mentor, or in any mentorship role, where allowed, must limit their support to general guidance. They must not contribute in any way that could be considered original authorship or that could enable claims of rights or ownership to the submitted entries. Under no circumstances will work on behalf of teams or individuals be allowed.

GENERAL STANDARDS FOR ENTRIES

In addition to the requirements listed above, all entries must meet the following general standards:

- Your entry must be your own original work. The video must be solely the work of the team, including but not limited to, the actual filming, editing, graphic design, etc. of the video; **and**
- You must have obtained all consents, approvals, or licenses required for you to submit your entry; **and**
- To the extent that entry requires the submission of user-generated content such as software, photos, videos, music, artwork, essays, etc., entrants warrant that their entry is their original work, has not been copied from others without permission or apparent rights, and does not violate the privacy, intellectual property rights, or other rights of any other person or entity. You may include Microsoft trademarks, logos, and designs, for which Microsoft grants you a limited license to use for the sole purposes of submitting an entry into this Contest; **and**
- You must not have used Microsoft property, internal resources, and/or the work of Microsoft employees, in connection with the creating your entry; **and**

- Your entry may NOT contain, as determined by us in our sole and absolute discretion, any content that is obscene or offensive, violent, defamatory, disparaging, or illegal, or that promotes alcohol, illegal drugs, tobacco or a particular political agenda, or that communicates messages that may reflect negatively on the goodwill of Microsoft.

Copyright
Your entire entry must only include material (including source code – both open source and third party sourced, user interface, music, video, or images) that you own or that you have permission to use from the copyright/trademark owner. Your entry will be disqualified if it includes copyrighted materials (such as source code, user interface, background music, images, or video) without appropriate licensing or permissions. If you use permissible copyrighted materials, you must include permissions information by citing the artist/creator and license information as per the Competition Rules. Note that even material released under sites such as Creative Commons, common open-source code licenses, and other similar licensing may need permission or acknowledgement as per the specific license. Note: your team's entry will be disqualified if permissions information is not included as per the requirements in the specific Competition Rules.

Health Related Solutions
If your entry includes health-related products or devices, you are solely responsible for obtaining any legal or regulatory clearances or approvals required to commercialize your entry. You are also solely responsible for the design, development, and implementation of your entry and for providing end users with appropriate warnings. You are solely responsible for any personal injury that may occur from the use of your entry, including (without limitation) any such injuries to end users. The Sponsor does not endorse, approve, recommend, warrant or guarantee, and provides no opinion, recommendation, or advice regarding the accuracy, integrity, quality, safety, efficacy, suitability, or use of entries, including but not limited to use of the entry for health, medical, or patient care purposes.

GENERAL CONDITIONS AND RELEASE OF LIABILITY
To the extent allowed by law, by entering you agree to release and hold harmless Microsoft and its respective parents, partners, subsidiaries, affiliates, employees, and agents from any and all liability or any injury, loss, or damage of any kind arising in connection with this Competition or any prize won.

All local laws apply. The decisions of Microsoft are final and binding.

We reserve the right to cancel, change, or suspend this Competition for any reason, including cheating, technology failure, catastrophe, war, or any other unforeseen or unexpected event that affects the integrity of this Competition, whether human or mechanical. If the integrity of the Competition cannot be restored, we may select winners from among all eligible entries received before we had to cancel, change or suspend the Competition.

If you attempt or we have strong reason to believe that you have compromised the integrity or the legitimate operation of this Contest by cheating, hacking, creating a bot or other automated

program, or by committing fraud in any way, we may seek damages from you to the full extent of the law and you may be banned from participation in future Microsoft promotions.

USE OF YOUR ENTRY

We are not claiming ownership rights to your entry. Microsoft does not take any equity in the businesses submitted to the Competition. All intellectual property rights for the entries remain with their respective owners. However, by submitting your entry, you grant us an irrevocable, royalty-free, worldwide right and license to use, review, assess, test, and otherwise analyze your entry and all its content in connection with this Competition and use your entry in any media whatsoever now known or later invented for any non-commercial or commercial purpose, including, but not limited to, the marketing, sale, or promotion of this Competition without further permission from you. You will not receive any compensation or credit for use of your entry, other than what is described in these Official Rules.

By entering, you acknowledge that we may have developed or commissioned materials similar or identical to your entry and you waive any claims resulting from any similarities to your entry**.** Further you understand that we will not restrict work assignments of representatives who have had access to your entry, and you agree that use of information in our representatives' unaided memories in the development or deployment of our products or services does not create liability for us under this agreement or copyright or trade secret law.

During and after this Competition, your entry may be posted on a public website. We are not responsible for any unauthorized use of your entry by visitors to this website. We are not obligated to use your entry for any purpose, even if it has been selected as a winning entry.

Personal data you provide while entering this Competition will be used by Microsoft and/or its agents and prize fulfillers acting on Microsoft's behalf only for the administration and operation of this Competition and in accordance with the Microsoft Privacy Statement.

If you do not want to grant us these rights to your entry, please do not enter this Competition.

GOVERNING LAW

This Competition will be governed by the laws of the State of Washington, and you consent to the exclusive jurisdiction and venue of the courts of the State of Washington for any disputes arising out of this Competition.

These Official Rules do not, nor do they purport to, limit, exclude or modify any non-excludable statutory guarantees as provided under the *Competition and Consumer Act 2010 (*Cth*)* or any other warranties (whether express or implied) under any Australian state or federal legislation which cannot be excluded.

WINNERS LIST

A list of final winners will be published as a blog post by May 30, 2025.